

EVALUATING AUDIENCE EXPERIENCE IN RELATION TO BOX OFFICE MANAGEMENT IN NIGERIAN THEATRE ORGANIZATIONS

BY

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Abstract

In contemporary theatre organizations, effective box office management plays a key role in shaping audience experience and ensuring organizational success. However, in Nigerian theatres, the limited understanding of how box office management practices influence audience experience and satisfaction in Nigerian theatre organizations has hindered the development of effective and efficient box office management systems. This study is anchored on Revenue Management Theory and Technology Acceptance Theory to explain box office efficiency and audience patronage in Nigerian theatre organizations. The study adopted descriptive survey research design. The population of the study comprised 961 theatre patrons and administrators from the University of Uyo, University of Benin, Terra Kulture, and Crown Troupe of Africa theatres. A sample of 400 respondents were used, and 388 questionnaires were retrieved. The instrument titled: Box Office Management in Nigerian Theatres Questionnaire (BOMNTQ) was used. Mean and standard deviation answered research questions while ANOVA tested the hypotheses at a 0.05 significance level. Cronbach Alpha method was used to determine a reliability index of 0.91 for University of Uyo, 0.93 for University of Benin, 0.91 for Terra Kulture, and 0.80 for Crown Troupe of Africa theatres. The study found that respondents identified key factors influencing attendance at theatrical performances, including production quality, play theme, word-of-mouth, performance schedule, location, online ticketing, and in-person box offices, impact audience satisfaction with box office operation. Key determinants include ease of purchasing, customer service, seat availability, and ticket collection efficiency. The study recommended among others that Nigerian theatre organizations should professionalize box office operations by training dedicated staff in customer service, ticketing procedures, and audience relations to enhance audience experience and satisfaction.

Keyword: Audience Perception, Audience Satisfaction, Box Office Management, Nigerian Theatre Organizations.

Introduction

The box office is an integral component of the theatre and entertainment industry, serving as a key indicator of a production's commercial success. Essentially, the box office refers to the sales of tickets for performances or events, but its influence extends far beyond this transactional role. Mankin and Zorn (2023) add that box office sales are not only a measure of financial success but also a reflection of the production's cultural relevance and public appeal. In many ways, the box office is a direct link between the creators of the performance and the audience, shaping decisions about the continuation or closure of shows, the financial viability of touring, and even the future of certain types of performances.

Despite its financial significance, the box office also faces challenges, particularly with regard to

the evolving landscape of digital entertainment. The rise of streaming services and digital content has posed a challenge to traditional box office revenue models. Morrison (2023, pp. 89-100) affirms that, the increasing popularity of on-demand viewing has led to a decline in theatre attendance in some areas, especially for smaller and independent productions. Theatre organizations now need to adapt to the digital age by integrating virtual experiences, live streaming, and hybrid models to cater to changing consumer habits and preferences.

The box office is intertwined with the broader conversation about the future of the arts and its accessibility to diverse audiences. As Leung (2023, pp. 23-37) discusses, rising ticket prices can alienate certain demographics, particularly young people and marginalized communities, from attending live performances. This issue has sparked debates about the need for more accessible pricing models, subsidies, and government support to ensure that theatre remains an inclusive and diverse space. In this way, the box office serves not only as a financial tool but also as a reflection of the social dynamics surrounding access to the arts.

Commercial theatres and educational theatres were combined in this study to provide a comprehensive understanding of box office management and audience experience within the Nigerian theatre context. Educational theatres, which prioritize training and academic objectives, often operate with limited resources and informal box office structures, while commercial theatres are profit-driven and employ more professionalized ticketing and audience management systems. Including both types of organizations allows the study to capture diverse administrative practices and audience experiences, thereby strengthening the analytical depth and representativeness of the findings. This approach enhances the study's ability to assess how organizational structure and managerial orientation influence box office operations and audience satisfaction across the Nigerian theatre industry.

Commercial theatres rely heavily on box office revenue to sustain their operations. The primary goal of commercial theatres is to generate profits through ticket sales, sponsorships, and advertising. Effective box office administration is crucial in commercial theatre to ensure that revenue is maximized and expenses are minimized. While educational theatres are not commercially based, they still require revenue generation to support their operations. Educational theatres use box office revenue to fund production costs, maintain facilities, and support student learning experiences.

The aim of this study is to examine audience perception and satisfaction in box office management in Nigerian theatre organizations.

The objectives are to:

- i) identify the key factors that drive audience decision to attend a theatrical performance?
- ii) identify the audience preferred method of purchasing tickets to a theatrical performance?
- iii) identify the key factors that determine audience satisfaction with box office operation in theatrical production?

The following research questions guided the study:

- i) What are the key factors that drive audience decision to attend a theatrical

- performance?
- ii) What is the audience preferred method of purchasing tickets to a theatrical performance?
- iii) What are the key factors that determine audience satisfaction with box office operation in theatrical production?

Theoretical Framework

Box Office Management Theory

This theory conceptualizes the box office as a central administrative and service unit responsible for ticket sales, revenue accountability, audience access, and customer relations within theatre organizations (Byrnes, 2014). The theory emphasizes that the box office functions as the primary point of contact between the theatre and its audience, thereby playing a critical role in shaping audience experience and perception of organizational efficiency.

The theory is largely advanced within arts management scholarship by William J. Byrnes, who situates box office management within classical management principles such as planning, organizing, coordination, and control. Effective application of these principles ensures efficient ticketing procedures, professional staff conduct, transparency, and accountability, all of which influence audience satisfaction. In contrast, weak box office structures often result in service inefficiencies that negatively affect audience experience.

Revenue Management Theory

This theory explains how organizations maximize income from limited and perishable resources through strategic pricing, demand forecasting, and capacity control (Kimes, 1989). In the performing arts, unsold seats represent irrecoverable revenue loss, making pricing and seat allocation critical managerial concerns.

The theory is strongly associated with Robert G. Cross, who introduced revenue management (yield management) as a systematic approach to selling the right product to the right customer at the right time and price (Cross, 1997). Applied to theatre organizations, the theory explains how ticket pricing strategies, discounts, and seats categorization influence audience access, perceived value, and satisfaction with box office operations.

Technology Acceptance Model (TAM)

TAM explains user acceptance of technology based on two key constructs: perceived usefulness and perceived ease of use (Davis, 1989). The model predicts that individuals are more likely to adopt technologies they perceive as efficient, reliable, and easy to operate.

Developed by Fred D. Davis, TAM is relevant to this study in explaining audience acceptance of digital box office systems such as online ticketing platforms, mobile payments, and electronic reservations. In theatre contexts, audience perceptions of convenience, speed, and system reliability directly affect ticket purchasing preferences and overall experience.

Audience Development Theory

This theory focuses on strategies used by arts organizations to attract, retain, and deepen relationships with audiences through accessibility, engagement, and satisfaction (Hill et al.,

2003). The theory positions audiences as active participants whose experiences and needs must be central to organizational planning.

Hill, O'Sullivan, and O'Sullivan emphasize that audience development extends beyond increasing attendance to include removing barriers such as cost, communication gaps, and service inefficiencies. Box office operations play a crucial role in this process, as ticket pricing, accessibility, and staff interaction significantly influence audience participation and loyalty.

Consumer Behavior Theory

The theory examines how individuals make decisions regarding the selection, purchase, use, and evaluation of goods and services (Schiffman & Kanuk, 2004). The theory identifies psychological, social, and economic factors such as motivation, perception, perceived risk, and satisfaction as determinants of consumer choice.

Applied to theatre attendance, the theory explains how audience decisions are influenced by ticket affordability, ease of purchase, previous box office experiences, and perceived value. Positive box office encounters reinforce favorable attitudes and increase the likelihood of repeat attendance, while negative experiences discourage future patronage.

Concept of Box Office

The box office is a platform for the sales of tickets to admit members of the audience to a commercial performance. The platform could be physical structure, a designated point in a theatre building, an online platform or mobile ticket seller's position. The box office, historically the site for ticket purchases has evolved into a critical administrative and financial unit within entertainment venues. It functions not only as the point of sale but also as the interface through which audiences engage with the organization (Langley, 2017). As such, the box office serves as a barometer for public interest and a source of vital operational data. Globally, box office performance is often used to evaluate the commercial success of films, plays, and other events (Marich, 2013). It influences not only revenue but also strategic decisions concerning programming and production continuity. In countries like the United States and the United Kingdom, box office data is systematically tracked and publicly reported, contributing to transparency and informed decision-making.

The box office originated in early modern European theatre, particularly during the Elizabethan era. Audience attending performances at venues like the Globe Theatre would pay for admission at a wooden box stationed at the gate, from which the term "box office" was derived (Gurr, 1996). These early practices laid the foundation for ticket-based entry and financial accountability in performance arts. The 17th and 18th centuries saw the rise of permanent theatres in cities such as London and Paris. With structured seating and hierarchical ticketing systems, the box office began to evolve into a more organized component of theatre administration (Booth, 1991). The industrial revolution further institutionalized the box office, allowing for increased audience capacity and the need for more formal ticketing processes.

In 20th century, the growth of cinema expanded the box office concept. Hollywood and other film industries began using box office earnings as a primary measure of success, giving rise to terms

such as “box office hit” (Marich, 2013). Modern technologies, such as online ticketing and real-time revenue tracking, have revolutionized box office operations across the globe (Laudon & Laudon, 2020). The COVID 19 pandemic further altered box office dynamics. Many institutions shifted temporarily to virtual performances, challenging traditional ticketing models and forcing a re-evaluation of how revenue could be generated from digital audiences (Walmsley, 2021).

The concept of the box office is closely tied to the economic realities of theatre and entertainment industries. Box office sales are essential for determining the profitability of a show, often covering the costs of production, salaries, and marketing efforts. (Nyasha, 2023) maintains that the success of a production is frequently measured by its box office performance, with high ticket sales signaling not only financial success but also the cultural relevance of the production. However, the importance of box office revenue also raises questions about the commercialization of art, where the need for profitability can overshadow creative experimentation. An important aspect of the box office's role in commercial theatre is its influence on the creative and marketing decisions made by producers and theatre companies.

Box Office Management in Nigeria

Box office management is a critical part of the financial success of any theatrical production, particularly in Nigeria, where financial sustainability in the arts often depends heavily on ticket sales. Best practices help ensure efficient and transparent operations, enabling theaters to optimize their revenue, manage resources effectively, and provide a positive customer experience.

The current practices for box office management in the theatre industry have evolved significantly with advancements in technology and changes in consumer behavior. Modern box office management practices encompass a range of strategies and tools aimed at enhancing efficiency, improving customer experience, and maximizing revenue. One of the primary practices in box office management is the adoption of sophisticated ticketing software. These systems allow theatres to manage ticket sales, track inventory, and analyze sales data in real time. According to research by Gill et al. (2021), ticketing software platforms offer features such as dynamic pricing, customer relationship management (CRM) integration, and marketing automation. Dynamic pricing, in particular, enables theatres to adjust ticket prices based on demand, optimizing revenue by selling tickets at higher prices during peak times and offering discounts during off-peak periods.

Customer relationship management is another critical component of contemporary box office management. CRM systems help theatres build and maintain relationships with their patrons by collecting and analyzing data on customer preferences and purchasing behavior. This data-driven approach allows theatres to tailor their marketing efforts, offering personalized promotions and incentives to increase customer loyalty and repeat business (Smith & Jones, 2022). The integration of mobile technology has also transformed box office management. Mobile ticketing apps provide a convenient way for customers to purchase and store tickets, reducing the need for physical ticketing and improving the overall customer experience. A study by Williams et al (2020) found that, mobile ticketing not only streamlines the purchasing

process but also enhances security by reducing the risk of ticket fraud and loss.

Another trend in box office management is the emphasis on data analytics. Theatres are increasingly leveraging data analytics to gain insights into sales trends, customer demographics, and marketing effectiveness. These insights enable theatres to make informed decisions about pricing strategies, promotional campaigns, and event scheduling. For instance, data analytics can help identify the most popular shows and peak buying times, allowing theatres to optimize their programming and marketing efforts accordingly (Brown, 2023). Additionally, many theatres are adopting contactless payment systems in response to the COVID-19 pandemic. Contactless payments not only enhance customer safety by minimizing physical contact but also expedite the transaction process, leading to shorter wait times and increased customer satisfaction. Research by Davis and Miller (2021) highlights that, contactless payment option has become a standard expectation among consumers, necessitating their adoption by theatres to remain competitive. Also, social media integration has become a vital practice in box office management. Theatres use social media platforms to engage with their audience, promote upcoming shows, and facilitate direct ticket sales through integrated links. Social media campaigns can generate buzz and drive ticket sales by reaching a broad audience quickly and effectively (Johnson, 2022).

Box office management in theatres is a multifaceted endeavor that integrates traditional practices with modern technological advancements to optimize operations, enhance customer experience, and maximize revenue. This field encompasses ticket sales, customer service, data management, marketing, and financial accounting, each playing a critical role in ensuring the theater's success. One of the primary practices in box office management is the integration of advanced ticketing systems. These systems facilitate online and mobile ticket sales, which have become increasingly crucial in the digital age.

Ultimately, box office management in Nigeria extends beyond the collection of revenue; it is a strategic tool for audience development and cultural sustainability. By leveraging both traditional and digital approaches, Nigerian theatre organizations can not only secure financial stability but also expand their audience base, enhance loyalty, and strengthen the visibility of theatre in the broader cultural economy.

Digital Ticketing Systems in Nigeria

The integration of digital technology into theatre operations has significantly reshaped the nature of box office administration in Nigeria. As theatres strive to remain relevant and accessible in an increasingly digital society, digital ticketing has become a crucial innovation. It represents a paradigm shift from the conventional, paper-based ticketing systems to a more dynamic, technology-driven process that aligns with global administrative best practices in the creative industries.

Historically, box office operations in Nigerian theatres were handled through manual processes involving handwritten tickets, paper registers, and on-site payments (Iyorza & Ugande, 2018). These systems were limited by inefficiencies, including susceptibility to fraud, inadequate record-keeping and restricted customer reach. As theatre productions grew, in scale and audience expectations evolved, it became clear that box office administration needed

modernization. The emergence of digital ticketing platforms such as Ariiyatickets, Afritickets, and Niger Tickets shop signified a turning point in how Nigerian theatre administrators approached ticket sales and audience management (Oyekan, 2021). These platforms introduced online payment systems, digital QR codes, automated receipts, and real-time reporting capabilities that addressed many of the limitations, inherent in manual systems. Consequently, the box office is no longer merely a point of sale but a data-driven administrative hub that informs broader theatre management decisions.

Digital ticketing systems offer several advantages to theatre administrators. Chief among them is enhanced financial transparency. Digital platforms provide traceable, automated transactions that minimize cash handling and help prevent revenue loss, a common challenge in traditional box office models (Adeyemi, 2022). Moreover, administrative staff can access real-time sales reports, analyze audience behavior, and forecast attendance with greater accuracy. This data-driven approach facilitates more strategic marketing, scheduling, and budgeting processes within the administrative framework (Eze & Olamide, 2020).

Despite these benefits, Nigerian theatre administrators face several challenges in adopting digital ticketing systems. One critical issue is infrastructural inadequacy; intermittent power supply, poor internet connectivity, and limited access to digital tools hinder seamless operations in many parts of the country (Ogunleye, 2019). These limitations pose significant obstacles, especially for theatres in less urbanized or underfunded settings.

Revenue Generation and Financial Management

Revenue generation and financial management are fundamental to the survival and growth of theatre organizations. In Nigeria, the theatre landscape comprises a mix of publicly funded institutions and privately run establishments, each facing unique financial challenges and adopting different strategies for revenue sustenance. Theatre organizations in Nigeria generate revenue through a variety of channels, including ticket sales, sponsorships, grants, donations, and merchandising. However, ticket sales remain the most common and direct source of income. The financial viability of many theatre organizations is closely linked to effectiveness of their box office operations, which serve as the principal point of revenue collection (Fayemi, 2019). In recent years, the push toward commercialization and the rise of the creative economy have led several Nigerian theatres to explore alternative revenue streams such as digital streaming, partnership events, and educational programs (Akinwale, 2019).

Financial management in these organizations is often influenced by their structural set-up. Privately run theatres tend to employ more formal financial systems, including budget planning, financial audits, and the use of accounting software (Adedeji, 2021). These practices enable such theatres to maintain financial transparency, plan long-term investments, and adapt to market fluctuations. In contrast, some public or institution-based theatres operate under broader bureaucratic frameworks where financial decisions are embedded in larger administrative structures, sometimes leading to inefficiencies and limited financial autonomy (Uzochukwu, 2017).

Despite the evident economic potential of the performing arts sector in Nigeria, government support remains inconsistent. While national cultural policies acknowledge the value of the arts, funding and infrastructural backing are minimal, leaving many theatre organizations to rely on self-generated income (Nwachukwu, 2020). As a result, financial sustainability is often tied to the creativity and managerial skills of the theatre's leadership and administrative staff.

Marketing and audience development also play a crucial role in revenue generation. Theatres that actively promote their productions through traditional media, social media, and community engagement tend to experience better ticket sales and audience loyalty (Okonkwo & Ajayi, 2020). Strategic pricing, special discounts, and promotional events are also used to boost attendance and revenue. In terms of financial control, internal accounting practices vary widely. Some organizations implement rigorous internal controls with trained financial personnel and clear accountability structures. Others, particularly smaller or institution-affiliated theatres, may struggle with informal record-keeping and inconsistent financial oversight (Omoregie, 2018). These disparities affect not only day-to-day operations but also long-term planning and access to funding opportunities.

Consequently, revenue generation and financial management are complex yet essential aspects of theatre administration in Nigeria. While some organizations have embraced innovation and formal financial systems, others continue to face structural and institutional challenges. A more robust financial management culture, supported by training, policy reform, and infrastructural investment, is essential for the long-term sustainability of Nigerian theatre organizations.

Audience Behavior and Theatre Attendance in Nigeria

Understanding audience behavior and patterns of theatre attendance is central to effective theatre administration and marketing strategy. In Nigeria, theatre attendance is influenced by a variety of cultural, socio-economic, demographic, and infrastructural factors, making audience behavior a critical area of study for theatre organizations seeking sustainability and relevance. Audience behavior in the Nigerian theatre context is shaped largely by cultural preferences, access to entertainment options, and the perceived value of live theatre. Research indicates that audiences are drawn to theatre experiences that relate to relatable themes, indigenous aesthetics, and socio-political commentary (Ogunyemi, 2017). Nigerian theatre, particularly in urban centers, often blends traditional performance elements with modern narratives, thus, attracting audiences with a shared cultural and linguistic background (Bassey & Nwosu, 2021).

Socio-economic factors play a major role in theatre attendance. Disposable income, educational level, occupation influence how frequently individuals attend live performances. Theatre has traditionally been seen as an elite or academic form of entertainment, especially in urban and institutional settings, which can alienate lower-income or less-educated populations (Adeyemi, 2018). This perception affects audience size and diversity, especially in areas where cinema and digital entertainment offer more affordable and accessible alternatives. Geography and infrastructure also impact theatre attendance in many Nigerian cities, traffic congestion, and transportation costs, and safety concerns discourage potential audiences from attending live shows, especially evening performances (Okoro & Ibrahim, 2019). Additionally, the irregular power supply, poor maintenance of theatre facilities, and inadequate public performance spaces

further limit consistent audience engagement, particularly in non-metropolitan areas.

Demographic variables such as age and gender significantly influence audience participation. Studies have shown that younger audiences (ages 18 – 35) are more likely to attend performances that integrate multimedia elements, humor, music, and contemporary themes (Eze, 2020). In contrast, older audiences tend to prefer traditional or classic dramatic forms. Gender dynamics also affect attendance, as female audiences may face societal or familial restrictions when attending events alone or at night (Usman & Oladimeji, 2021).

The role of educational institutions in cultivating audience interest cannot be overstated. Theatre appreciation courses, campus productions, and cultural festivals help introduce students to the art of live performance and often contribute to lifelong theatre engagement (Ajibola, 2019). However, the lack of sustained audience development strategies in many regions has hindered the growth of a stable and enthusiastic theatre-going public.

In conclusion, audience behavior and theatre attendance in Nigeria are influenced by a complex interplay of cultural, economic, demographic, and infrastructural factors. To improve attendance and audience loyalty, theatre organizations must adopt adaptive, inclusive, and technologically informed strategies that resonate with diverse audience segments. Long-term investment in audience education, targeted outreach, and infrastructural development remains essential for the continued growth of live theatre in Nigeria.

Hypotheses

The following hypotheses raised were tested at 0.05 level of significance:

- i) There is no significant difference on the key factors that drive the audience's decision to attend a theatrical performance among box office operation in university of Uyo Theatre, University of Benin Theatre, Tara Kulture theatre, and Crown Troupe of African Theatre.
- ii) There is no significant difference on the audience's preferred method of purchasing tickets to a theatrical performance among box office operation in university of Uyo theatre, University of Benin Theatre, Tara Kulture theatre, and Crown Troupe of African theatre.
- iii) There is no significant difference on the key factors that determine the audience's satisfaction with box office operation in theatrical production among box office operation in university of Uyo theatre, University of Benin Theatre, Tara Kulture theatre, and Crown Troupe of African theatre.

Methodology

The researcher adopted the descriptive survey research design for the study. The population of this study comprised 961 theatre patrons who have watched theatrical performances in the university of Uyo, university of Benin, Terra Kulture, and Crown Troupe of Africa theatres over a five-year period. The researcher used both basic random sampling and purposeful sampling to arrive at the appropriate sample size for this investigation which involved 400 male and female theatre patrons who have watched theatrical performances in the university of Uyo, university of Benin, Terra Kulture, and Crown Troupe of Africa theatres. Data for this study were gathered

from both primary and secondary sources. The researcher with the aid of two trained research assistants distributed 400 questionnaires among the respondents while 388 copies of the questionnaires were retrieved. The questionnaire designed titled: Box Office Management in Nigerian Theatres Questionnaire (BOMNTQ) was used. The questionnaire was made of two sections (A and B); section A, contain demographic information, while section B was ordered based on variables with 15-items which were patterned on modified Likert type rating scale of Strongly Agree (SA) 4-points, Agree (A) 3-points, Disagree (D) 2-points and Strongly Disagree (SD) 1-point.

Mean and standard deviation answered the research questions, while Analysis of Variance (ANOVA) tested hypotheses at 0.05 level of significance whereby $p\text{-value} > 0.05$ assigned accepted; $p\text{-value} < 0.05$ assigned rejected. The instruments were submitted to the experts for face and content validation. Comments and corrections made by the experts were used to enhance the value of the instruments to make it valid. The questionnaire instrument was administered twice within a two-weeks to 30 respondents of the cities of Uyo, Benin and Lagos outside the sample. The scores of both tests instruments were correlated and computed using Cronbach Alpha method with reliability Index of 0.91 for University of Uyo, 0.93 for University of Benin, 0.91 for Terra Kulture and 0.80 for Crown Troupe of Africa theatres, signifying that the instrument is reliable.

Results and Discussion

Research Question One: What are the key factors that drive the audiences' decision to attend a theatrical performance?

Table 1: Mean scores of the respondents on the key factors that drive the audiences' decision to attend a theatrical performance in UniUyo, UniBenin, Terra Kulture and Crown Troupe of Africa Theatres

S/N	Items for decision variables	Uyo (n=96)		Benin (n=97)		Terra Kulture (n=98)		Crown Troupe of Africa Theatres (n=97)		Mean Set	Remark
		Mean (x)	Std. Dev.	Mean (x)	Std. Dev.	Mean (x)	Std. Dev.	Mean (x)	Std. Dev.		
1.	Quality of the production and reputation of the theatre	2.96	.59	2.96	.58	3.16	.65	3.29	.68	3.09	Accepted
2.	Interest in the play's theme or storyline	3.01	.54	3.00	.53	3.29	.46	3.25	.73	3.14	Accepted
3.	Positive word-of-mouth and reviews	2.99	.55	2.99	.54	3.24	.51	3.26	.78	3.12	Accepted
4	Convenience of the performance schedule and location	3.00	.56	3.00	.54	3.26	.52	3.28	.75	3.14	Accepted
5	Ticket pricing and discounts	2.99	.53	2.99	.52	3.25	.44	3.19	.79	3.11	Accepted
	Grand Mean/Std.Dev.	2.99	.58	2.99	.54	3.24	.52	3.25	.75	3.12	Accepted

* Accept $2.50 > 2.49$. Reject $2.50 < 2.49$

Sources: Field Survey, 2025

The results in Table 1 shows the mean and standard deviation scores of respondents from UniUyo, UniBenin, Terra Kulture, and Crown Troupe of Africa Theatres, with regard to the key factors influencing their decision to attend a theatrical performance. All the factors such as quality of production, interest in the play's theme, positive word-of-mouth, convenience of performance schedule and location, and ticket pricing received relatively high mean scores across the four theatres, ranging from 2.96 to 3.29, indicating that respondents consider these factors as important. The grand mean across all theatres is 3.12, whereby respondents generally accepted that quality of production, interest in the play's theme, positive word-of-mouth, convenience of performance schedule and location, and ticket pricing are the key factors that drive the audiences' decision to attend a theatrical performance. It also emphasized that factors like production quality, the storyline, positive reviews, convenient schedules, and affordable ticket prices are critical to attracting audiences to theatrical performances in these theatres, and this insight can inform future strategies for theatre marketing and programming.

Research Question Two: What is the audiences' preferred method of purchasing tickets to a theatrical performance?

Table 2: Mean scores of the respondents on the audiences' preferred method of purchasing tickets to a theatrical performance in UniUyo, UniBenin, Terra Kulture and Crown Troupe of Africa Theatres

S/N	Items for decision variables	Uyo (n=96)		Benin (n=97)		Terra Kulture (n=98)		Crown Troupe of Africa Theatres (n=97)		Mean Set	Remark
		Mean (x)	Std. Dev.	Mean (x)	Std. Dev.	Mean (x)	Std. Dev.	Mean (x)	Std. Dev.		
6.	Online ticketing through theatre websites	2.98	.56	3.00	.83	3.23	.64	3.26	.73	3.12	Accepted
7.	Mobile apps	2.98	.60	3.53	.50	3.20	.49	3.24	.78	3.24	Accepted
8.	In-person box office purchases	2.97	.54	3.22	.77	3.16	.51	3.23	.79	3.15	Accepted
9.	Third-party online ticketing platforms	2.96	.54	2.77	.86	3.09	.53	3.29	.72	3.03	Accepted
10.	Phone reservations and purchases	2.93	.54	2.82	.83	3.25	.61	3.26	.71	3.07	Accepted
	Grand Mean/Std.Dev.	2.96	.56	3.07	.76	3.19	.56	3.26	.75	3.12	Accepted

* Accept $2.50 > 2.49$. Reject $2.50 < 2.49$

Sources: Field Survey, 2025

The results in Table 2 shows the mean and standard deviation scores for the preferred methods of purchasing tickets to a theatrical performance across the four theatres. The highest mean scores were for mobile app ticketing (3.24) and online ticketing through theatre websites (3.12), indicating that respondents prefer online methods for purchasing tickets. In-person box office

purchases also received moderate ratings (3.15), while third-party online platforms and phone reservations were slightly less preferred, with mean scores around 3.03 and 3.07 respectively. The grand mean score of 3.12 across all theatres suggests that, generally, respondents prefer online and mobile app ticketing over traditional in-person or phone reservation methods. It was highlighted that the growing preference for online and mobile app ticketing presents an opportunity for theatres to enhance their digital platforms and improve audience accessibility to tickets, thus aligning with current trends in consumer behaviour.

Research Question Three: What are the key factors that determine audiences' satisfaction with box office operation in theatrical productions?

Table 3: Mean scores of the respondents on the key factors that determine audiences' satisfaction with box office operation in theatrical productions in UniUyo, UniBenin, Terra Kulture and Crown Troupe of Africa Theatres

S/N	Items for decision variables	Uyo (n=96)		Benin (n=97)		Terra Kulture (n=98)		Crown Troupe of Africa Theatres (n=97)		Mean Set	Remark
		Mean (x)	Std. Dev.	Mean (x)	Std. Dev.	Mean (x)	Std. Dev.	Mean (x)	Std. Dev.		
11.	Ease of ticket purchasing	2.91	.85	2.60	.03	3.08	.73	3.35	.67	2.99	Accepted
12.	Transparency in pricing	2.87	.80	3.06	.59	3.33	.95	3.33	.74	3.15	Accepted
13.	Customer service quality	3.16	.05	3.07	.65	3.47	.94	3.36	.66	3.27	Accepted
14.	Availability of preferred seats	3.01	.92	2.97	.94	3.24	.94	3.36	.69	3.15	Accepted
15.	Efficiency of ticket collection and entry	2.75	.92	2.80	.79	3.05	.93	3.32	.72	2.98	Accepted
	Grand Mean/Std.Dev.	2.94	.71	2.9	.6	3.23	.89	3.34	.70	3.11	Accepted

* Accept $2.50 > 2.49$. Reject $2.50 < 2.49$

Sources: Field Survey, 2025

The results in Table 3 reveals the key factors determining audience satisfaction with box office operation across the four theatres. Respondents rated customer service quality the highest (mean score of 3.27), followed by transparency in pricing (3.15) and the availability of preferred seats (3.15), indicating that these aspects play a significant role in their satisfaction. The ease of ticket purchasing, while important, received the lowest mean score (2.99), suggesting room for improvement. The grand mean score of 3.11 further supports the notion that, overall, satisfaction with box office operation is moderate to high. In all, respondents accepted that online ticketing through theatre websites, mobile apps, in-person box office purchases, third-party online ticketing platforms and phone reservations and purchases are the key factors that determine audience satisfaction with box office operation in theatrical productions. However,

the result emphasized the importance of improving customer service and transparency, while also focusing on enhancing the efficiency of ticket purchasing and collection processes to further boost audience satisfaction in theatre box office operations.

Hypotheses

Hypothesis 1: There is no significant difference on the key factors that drive the audience's decision to attend a theatrical performance among box office operation in University of Uyo theatre, University of Benin Theatre, Terra Kulture theatre, and Crown Troupe of Africa theatre.

Table 4: Anova test showing significant differences on the key factors that drive the audiences' decision to attend a theatrical performance among the selected theatres: university of Uyo theatre, University of Benin Theatre, Terra Kulture theatre, and Crown Troupe of African theatre.

	Sum of Squares	df	Mean Square	F	Sig.	Alpha
Between Groups	4.505	3	1.502			
Within Groups	117.000	384	.305	4.929	.002	0.05
Total	121.505	387				

* Significance 0.05 > 0.00. Not Significance 0.05 < 0.00

The ANOVA test presented in Table 4 indicated that there is a statistically significant difference in the key factors driving audiences' decisions to attend theatrical performances across the four studied theatres: University of Uyo Theatre, University of Benin Theatre, Terra Kulture Theatre, and Crown Troupe of African Theatre. With an F-value of 4.929 and a p-value (Sig.) of 0.002, which is less than the alpha level of 0.05, the result confirms that at least one group differs significantly from the others. This result highlighted the varying influences of box office operation in shaping audience preferences among these theatres. The researcher involved by emphasizing the importance of tailoring box office strategies to the unique audience dynamics and preferences specific to each theatre, enabling institutions to enhance attendance and engagement through evidence-based approaches.

Hypothesis 2: There is no significant difference on the audiences' preferred method of purchasing tickets to a theatrical performance among box office operation in university of Uyo theatre, University of Benin Theatre, Terra Kulture theatre, and Crown Troupe of Africa theatre.

Table 5: Anova test showing significant differences on the audiences' preferred method of purchasing tickets to a theatrical performance among box office operation in university of Uyo theatre, University of Benin Theatre, Terra Kulture theatre, and Crown Troupe of Africa theatre

	Sum of Squares	df	Mean Square	F	Sig.	Alpha
Between Groups	3.633	3	1.211			
Within Groups	128.003	384	.333	3.633	.001	0.05
Total	131.637	387				

* Significance $0.05 > 0.00$. Not Significance $0.05 < 0.00$

The ANOVA test presented in Table 5 reveals that there is a significant difference in the audiences' preferred methods of purchasing tickets to theatrical performances among the four theatres: University of Uyo Theatre, University of Benin Theatre, Terra Kulture Theatre, and Crown Troupe of Africa Theatre. With a between-groups sum of squares of 3.633 and a within-groups sum of squares of 128.003, the calculated F-value is 3.633, and the significance level (Sig.) is .001, which is below the alpha threshold of 0.05. This result indicates that at least one theatre's audience has a distinct preference for ticket purchasing methods compared to others. The researcher also provided insights into how these preferences may inform targeted ticketing strategies for theatre administrators, enhancing customer satisfaction and optimizing sales by adopting the most preferred methods in each context.

Hypothesis 3: There is no significant difference on the key factors that determine the audiences' satisfaction with box office operation in theatrical production among the selected theatres: University of Uyo theatre, University of Benin Theatre, Terra Kulture theatre, and Crown Troupe of Africa theatre.

Table 6: Anova test showing significant differences on the key factors that determine the audiences' satisfaction with box office operation in theatrical production among the selected theatres: University of Uyo theatre, University of Benin Theatre, Terra Kulture theatre, and Crown Troupe of Africa theatre.

	Sum of Squares	df	Mean Square	F	Sig.	Alpha
Between Groups	1.587	3	.529			
Within Groups	155.823	384	.406	1.303	.002	0.05
Total	157.410	387				

* Significance $0.05 > 0.00$. Not Significance $0.05 < 0.00$

The ANOVA test results presented in Table 6 indicates that there is a significant difference in the key factors determining audience satisfaction with box office operation across the University of Uyo Theatre, University of Benin Theatre, Terra Kulture Theatre, and Crown Troupe of African Theatre. The significance value (Sig. = .002) is less than the alpha level of 0.05, confirming that at least one of the groups differs significantly in audience satisfaction. The F-value of 1.303, derived from the mean square between groups (0.529) and within groups (0.406), reflects variations among the groups compared to the overall variability within them. The researcher involved by contextualizing recommended strategies tailored to the unique operational

practices of each theatre, thereby enhancing audience satisfaction and improving box office management standards across diverse theatre settings.

Discussion

The selected theories provide a comprehensive framework for evaluating audience experience in relation to box office management in Nigerian theatre organizations. Consumer Behavior Theory and Audience Development Theory explain the key factors that drive audience decisions to attend theatrical performances, including motivation, accessibility, affordability, and prior experience. These theories align with Research Question One, which focuses on attendance determinant.

Findings from research question one revealed that respondents generally accepted that quality of production, interest in the play's theme, positive word-of-mouth, convenience of performance schedule and location, and ticket pricing are the key factors that drive the audiences' decision to attend a theatrical performance. The result also emphasizes that factors like production quality, the storyline, positive reviews, convenient schedules, and affordable ticket prices are critical to attracting audiences to theatrical performances in these theatres, and this insight can inform future strategies for theatre marketing and programming. The study also reveals that social influence (e.g., peer recommendations) was one of the significant factor in deciding to attend theatrical performance, the availability of free or discounted tickets was also an attractor, the timing of the performance (weekends) significantly affected attendance, audiences preferred performances that aligned with their interests (e.g., drama) and the quality of production (e.g., acting, sound, lighting) strongly influenced the decision.

Findings reveals that personal interest in the genre of the performance (e.g., drama, music) was the top factor for attendance, the reputation of the performers (actors, musicians) was crucial in drawing audiences, the convenience of the location (near to theatre) influenced attendance decisions, availability of social media promotions significantly impacted awareness of performances and price affordability was a decisive factor for audiences. The researcher found participants indicating that advertisements influenced their attendance, affordability of ticket prices emerged as an important factor. Most of the respondents expressed that high ticket costs would discourage them from attending a performance, convenient performance times, as well as easy accessibility to the venue, were key determinants. Hence, hypothesis one result stated that there is a significant difference in the key factors driving audiences' decisions to attend theatrical performances across the four studied theatres: University of Uyo Arts Theatre, University of Benin Arts Theatre, Terra Kulture Arts Theatre, and Crown Troupe of Africa Arts Theatre.

The Technology Acceptance Model, supported by Box Office Management Theory, explains audience preferences for ticket purchasing methods addressed in Research Question Two. Perceived usefulness, ease of use, efficiency, and convenience serve as key variables influencing whether audiences prefer digital or physical ticketing systems.

Findings from research question two indicates that respondents accepted that online ticketing through theatre websites, mobile apps, in-person box office purchases, third-party online ticketing platforms and phone reservations and purchases are the key factors that determine

audience satisfaction with box office operation in theatrical productions. It was highlighted that the growing preference for online and mobile app ticketing presents an opportunity for theatres to enhance their digital platforms and improve audience accessibility to tickets, thus aligning with current trends in consumer behavior, while hypothesis two result shows that there is a significant difference in the audience's preferred methods of purchasing tickets to theatrical performances

Research Question Three, which examines audience satisfaction with box office operations, is directly explained by Box Office Management Theory, Revenue Management Theory, and Consumer Behavior Theory. Variables such as staff professionalism, transaction efficiency, pricing fairness, perceived value, and service quality are central to understanding audience satisfaction.

Findings from research question three reveals that respondents agreed that ease of ticket purchasing, transparency in pricing, customer service quality, availability of preferred seats and efficiency of ticket collection and entry are the key factors that determine audience satisfaction with box office operation in theatrical productions. The result emphasized the importance of improving customer service and transparency, while also focusing on enhancing the efficiency of ticket purchasing and collection processes to further boost audience satisfaction in theatre box office operations. The results of the study revealed that efficiency of ticketing staff was the most significant factor, with respondents highlighting its importance, transparent pricing and clear refund policies influenced satisfaction, and availability of tickets during peak demand was a crucial determinant. It also revealed that, friendly and knowledgeable box office staff significantly enhanced satisfaction, online ticketing options were preferred by respondents, citing convenience and time savings and transparent pricing policies were noted as crucial by attendees, especially students.

The study findings showed that efficient queue management systems were noted by respondents as critical to satisfaction, affordable ticket pricing attracted higher satisfaction among attendees, particularly students and clear communication of event details via social media significantly influenced satisfaction for respondents. Respondents valued transparent pricing as a significant factor in satisfaction, digital ticketing systems were preferred. Convenience and efficiency and prompt customer service during peak hours positively influenced satisfaction. Respondents cited efficient queue management as critical to their satisfaction, flexible ticket purchase options, including online and physical tickets, and clear communication about show schedules positively influenced satisfaction of respondents. Thus, hypothesis three result indicated that there is a statistically significant difference in the key factors determining audience satisfaction with box office management across the University of Uyo Theatre, University of Benin Theatre, Terra Kulture Theatre, and Crown Troupe of Africa Theatre.

Conclusion

The theories adopted for this study explain how managerial practices, pricing strategies, technology adoption, audience engagement, and consumer decision-making interact to shape audience experience. Their integration strengthens the theoretical foundation of the study and supports its objective of improving box office operations and audience satisfaction in Nigerian

theatre organizations.

This study contributes to knowledge by highlighting box office management as a key factor shaping audience experience in Nigerian theatre organizations. It extends theatre scholarship by integrating management, technology, and consumer behavior theories to explain audience satisfaction beyond performance aesthetics. By examining both commercial and educational theatre contexts, the study provides context-specific insights that inform audience-centered box office practices and support sustainable theatre management in Nigeria.

Recommendations

Based on the discoveries of this research and conclusion drawn, the following recommendations are made:

- Nigerian theatre organizations should professionalize box office operations by training dedicated staff in customer service, ticketing procedures, and audience relations to enhance audience experience and satisfaction.
- Theatre organizations should adopt and effectively manage hybrid ticketing systems that combine digital and physical ticket sales to accommodate diverse audience preferences and levels of technological access.
- Transparent and flexible pricing strategies should be implemented to improve perceived value and fairness, thereby increasing audience trust and attendance.
- Educational theatre organizations should integrate audience-centered box office practices into their administrative structures to bridge the gap between academic theatre practice and audience expectations.
- Theatre managers and policymakers should prioritize box office management as a strategic component of theatre sustainability and audience development in Nigeria.

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